Brigade HQ: ‘I overheard several telephone conversations…which gave me the impression that some of our Commanders, despite the resolute attitude of their Brigade Commander, could have displayed greater determination at the time. Soon after 4 Sikh and 3/3 Gorkhas began withdrawing from their positions under pressure. I heard Major Handoo telling several officers in various battalions over the telephone in no uncertain terms that they should give fighting (sic). Some of them did. Others did not.’

Lieutenant Colonel Yadav, CO of 3/3 GR, seems to have frozen. Had he responded to Palta’s desperate plea for help, it is unlikely that the outcome of the battle would have been different, but it may have given the remnants a fighting chance. It’s evident that the Chinese had not been able to effectively cut off the track between Dong and High Plateau since a small artillery forward observation party managed to get to Delta Company just before the position was overrun. As position after position on both the banks began to fall and Walong began to get shelled, Kaul gave Rawlley orders for battle that were vague enough to absolve the general of having ordered the withdrawal himself. In language typical of Kaul, he and Mohinder Pathania informed Rawlley: ‘…hold on to your present position to the best of your ability. If the position becomes untenable you are to take up an alternative position and man it to the best of your ability. In the event that also becomes untenable you are to continue to take up a series of layback positions and keep delaying the enemy.’

At noon Rawlley issued the order to all battalion commanding officers to break contact with the Chinese and withdraw. All elements of the brigade were to fall back to the Yapak Ti–Lohit River junction. Troops on the west bank (6 Kumaon, 4 Sikh and 4 Dogra) were to withdraw along the Yapak Ridge while 3/3 GR plus one company of 4 Sikh was to withdraw along the eastern track and link up with the brigade downstream at Hawai, which was roughly halfway between Walong and Hayuliang.

Though all the battalion HQs received the order, it is doubtful that it was passed on to the various sub-units. 6 Kumaon had already disintegrated at Trijunction and Mortar Post and the remaining men had a difficult time getting back to Walong to join the brigade group. As a result they dispersed in small parties, many of whom were subsequently ambushed and killed or captured by the Chinese. Lieutenant Colonel Madiah along with thirty men was also ambushed on the Yepak Plateau on 18 November. Every member of his party was killed while Madiah, who tried to escape by jumping into a